THE STEADY ROOM

The Steady Room Boundaries Workbook

Scripts, worksheets, and a 30-day practice plan for calm, kind, firm boundaries.

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What a boundary is (and isn't)

A boundary describes what you will do to protect your time, energy, body, or values. It is about your actions, not about controlling someone else.

Control says: 'You can't see your friends.' A boundary says: 'If plans change last minute, I'll make other plans for my evening.'

A boundary isn't a punishment, a threat, or a test. It's information about how you'll take care of yourself.

Think of a time you called something a boundary that was really a demand:

How would you rewrite it around your own action?

Boundary or request? The one-sentence test

Ask: can I do this without the other person's cooperation? If yes, it's a boundary. If no, it's a request, and requests are fine. They are simply a different tool.

Example request: 'Could you text if you'll be late?' Example boundary: 'If dinner is more than 30 minutes late without a text, I'll eat and put yours in the fridge.'

Five things I want to change:

Which are requests? Which are boundaries?

Mapping where you feel drained

Resentment is a signal. It often points at a limit you haven't named yet. Notice the moments you feel tense, tired, or 'used' afterward.

People or situations that leave me drained:

What exactly happens right before I feel that way?

What I wish I had said:

Your values and limits

Boundaries hold better when they come from what matters to you, not just what annoys you. Name three values, then the limit that protects each one.

My top three values:

Value 1 -> limit that protects it:

Value 2 -> limit:

Value 3 -> limit:

Writing a boundary in one sentence

Use: 'When ___ happens, I'm going to ___.' No history, no list of examples. The case is the part that gets argued with.

'When voices get raised, I'm going to step outside for ten minutes and come back.'

Boundary 1:

Boundary 2:

Boundary 3:

Read each aloud. What can I cut?

Choosing the right time to say it

Say it at a calm, neutral time, not in the middle of the problem. In person or by phone works better than text for anything important. Say it once, then pause.

When and where I'll say it:

My first sentence, word for word:

What I'll do in the silence afterward:

Follow-through: what you'll do

A boundary you never act on becomes a wish. Choose a follow-through small enough that you'll actually do it: leave the room, end the call, go home early.

First time it's crossed, I will:

Is that realistic? If not, make it smaller:

If it becomes a pattern:

Handling pushback and guilt

Pushback is normal. It doesn't mean you did it wrong. Acknowledge the feeling, repeat the plan: 'I know this is frustrating. My answer is still the same.'

Guilt is often the feeling of breaking an old rule, not proof you did something wrong.

The pushback I expect:

My calm repeat line:

The old rule my guilt is protecting:

Partners

Boundaries with a partner protect the relationship, too. Frame them as 'us against the problem.'

'I want to hear this, and I can't do it at 11 pm. Can we talk at breakfast?'

One boundary I need with my partner:

How it helps us, not just me:

Parents and in-laws

Usually each partner speaks to their own family. Agree as a couple first. Offer connection alongside the limit: a different date, a call, a shorter visit.

What we agree on as a couple:

Who will say it, and what they'll say:

Friends

Friendships handle honesty better than we fear. Most people would rather know than guess.

A friendship pattern I want to change:

My message:

Work

Work boundaries are about clarity, not attitude: 'I can get this to you Thursday. If it's needed sooner, which of these should I move?'

Where work spills into my life:

My clear, professional line:

Digital and phone boundaries

Decide your own reply windows, notifications, and phone-free times, then let people know once.

My phone-free times:

My message to friends or family:

Money boundaries

Lending, gifting, splitting costs: decide your limit before the ask arrives. 'I don't lend money, but I'm happy to help you look at options.'

My money limits:

My script:

Repair after conflict

Repair beats perfection. Name your part, show you care, suggest a next step. 'I got sharp earlier, and I'm sorry. I'd like to try that conversation again.'

A conflict that needs repair:

My part in it:

My repair message:

The 20-minute break

When you're flooded, nobody can listen well. Agree ahead of time: either person can call a break, you name a return time, and you come back.

Our break signal:

What I'll do during the break to calm down:

Our return rule:

People-pleasing self-check

Mark each that's often true: I say yes before thinking. I over-explain my no. I feel responsible for others' moods. I avoid asking for what I need. I agree, then resent it. I apologize for things that aren't mine.

Three or more? Start with the smallest boundary on your list this week.

My score and what I notice:

60 ready-to-use scripts

1. I can't take that on right now.
2. That doesn't work for me, but here's what I can do.
3. Let me think about it and get back to you tomorrow.
4. I'm going to pass this time. Thank you for asking.
5. I'd like to finish my thought, then I'll listen.
6. I'm not willing to talk while we're shouting. I'll be back in 20 minutes.
7. Please don't comment on my body.
8. I'm not discussing that today.
9. I don't lend money, but I'm glad to help you look at options.
10. I reply to messages in the evening.
11. I'm offline after 8 pm.
12. We'll be there from 2 to 5.
13. We've booked a hotel for this visit.
14. We're keeping gifts under $25.
15. I need some quiet time when I get home. Give me 20 minutes.
16. I'm happy to help on Saturday morning, not the whole day.
17. That's a private topic for me.
18. I'm not going to keep arguing about this. My answer is still no.
19. I hear you're upset. I'm still going to leave at 9.
20. I'd rather you ask me directly than hear it secondhand.
21. I can't be your only support on this. Could we find someone else who can help too?
22. If you raise your voice, I'll end the call and we can try later.
23. I'm not comfortable with that joke.
24. I need you to knock before coming in.
25. Please check with me before sharing photos of the kids.
26. I can stay for one hour.
27. I'm not ready to talk about that yet.
28. I'd like us to decide that together.
29. I can't make it, but I'd love to see you next week.
30. I'm going to stop here for tonight.

31. I'd like to keep work talk to work hours.
32. Let's split this evenly.
33. I'm not taking calls during dinner.
34. I won't be able to host this year.
35. I need a yes or no by Friday so I can plan.
36. I'm going to sit this one out.
37. That's not something I'll change, but I appreciate you telling me how you feel.
38. Please don't read my messages.
39. I'd like some time alone this weekend. It isn't about you.
40. I'm going to leave if this continues.
41. I'm not okay with being spoken to that way.
42. I can listen for ten minutes, then I need to go.
43. Let's revisit this when we're both calm.
44. I'm choosing not to drink tonight.
45. I'll handle my side of the family.
46. I'm not going to explain my decision again.
47. Thank you. I'm going to do it my way.
48. I'm keeping my weekends free this month.
49. I need you to tell me if you'll be late.
50. I'm going to put my phone away while we talk.
51. That's my limit.
52. I love you, and I'm still saying no.
53. I'm not able to lend the car.
54. I'd like a heads-up before visits.
55. I'll be quiet for a minute so I can think.
56. I don't share my salary.
57. I'm not taking sides.
58. I want to help, and I can't fix this for you.
59. I'm going to bed. Let's finish tomorrow.
60. I'm proud of this decision.

30-day practice plan

Day 1: Notice one moment of resentment. [ ]

Day 2: Write it down without judging. [ ]

Day 3: Sort your list: boundary or request? [ ]

Day 4: Pick the smallest boundary. [ ]

Day 5: Write it in one sentence. [ ]

Day 6: Say it aloud three times. [ ]

Day 7: Choose when you'll say it. [ ]

Day 8: Say it. Then stop talking. [ ]

Day 9: Note how it went. [ ]

Day 10: Plan your follow-through. [ ]

Day 11: Practice one polite no. [ ]

Day 12: Try one reply window. [ ]

Day 13: Make one small request. [ ]

Day 14: Repeat a boundary calmly if needed. [ ]

Day 15: Rest. Review week two. [ ]

Day 16: Pick a medium boundary. [ ]

Day 17: Agree a break signal with someone. [ ]

Day 18: Practice your repeat line. [ ]

Day 19: Say it. [ ]

Day 20: Follow through once. [ ]

Day 21: Notice guilt. Name the old rule. [ ]

Day 22: Do one repair conversation. [ ]

Day 23: Set one money or time limit. [ ]

Day 24: Celebrate one win. [ ]

Day 25: Pick a boundary for your family. [ ]

Day 26: Write your message. [ ]

Day 27: Agree with your partner first. [ ]

Day 28: Send or say it. [ ]

Day 29: Review what changed. [ ]

Day 30: Write your next month's focus. [ ]

Boundary Plan worksheet 1 of 7

Situation / person:

What I feel and what I need:

Boundary or request?

My one sentence:

When and where I will say it:

My follow-through:

If they push back:

How it went:

Boundary Plan worksheet 2 of 7

Situation / person:

What I feel and what I need:

Boundary or request?

My one sentence:

When and where I will say it:

My follow-through:

If they push back:

How it went:

Boundary Plan worksheet 3 of 7

Situation / person:

What I feel and what I need:

Boundary or request?

My one sentence:

When and where I will say it:

My follow-through:

If they push back:

How it went:

Boundary Plan worksheet 4 of 7

Situation / person:

What I feel and what I need:

Boundary or request?

My one sentence:

When and where I will say it:

My follow-through:

If they push back:

How it went:

Boundary Plan worksheet 5 of 7

Situation / person:

What I feel and what I need:

Boundary or request?

My one sentence:

When and where I will say it:

My follow-through:

If they push back:

How it went:

Boundary Plan worksheet 6 of 7

Situation / person:

What I feel and what I need:

Boundary or request?

My one sentence:

When and where I will say it:

My follow-through:

If they push back:

How it went:

Boundary Plan worksheet 7 of 7

Situation / person:

What I feel and what I need:

Boundary or request?

My one sentence:

When and where I will say it:

My follow-through:

If they push back:

How it went:

Reflection and next steps

Which boundary made the biggest difference?

What got easier?

Where do I still over-explain?

My focus for next month:

If someone hurts you or you feel unsafe, boundaries aren't enough on their own. Please reach out to a licensed professional or, in the US, the National Domestic Violence Hotline (1-800-799-7233) or 988.